

No Kill Colorado

Return-to-Owner (RTO) rate & life-saving strategies (2015–2024)

Filters

year

animal catego...

animal type

Facility



Overall Average, 2015-2024

|               |                 |                            |
|---------------|-----------------|----------------------------|
| stray intakes | return to owner | Return-to-Owner (RTO) Rate |
| 614,073       | 256,397         | 42%                        |

This dashboard visualizes RTO trends to identify strategic disparities and opportunities for growth in Colorado. Our analysis shows a significant operational challenge in Cat reunification and highlights the need for a targeted, dual-species No-Kill strategy.

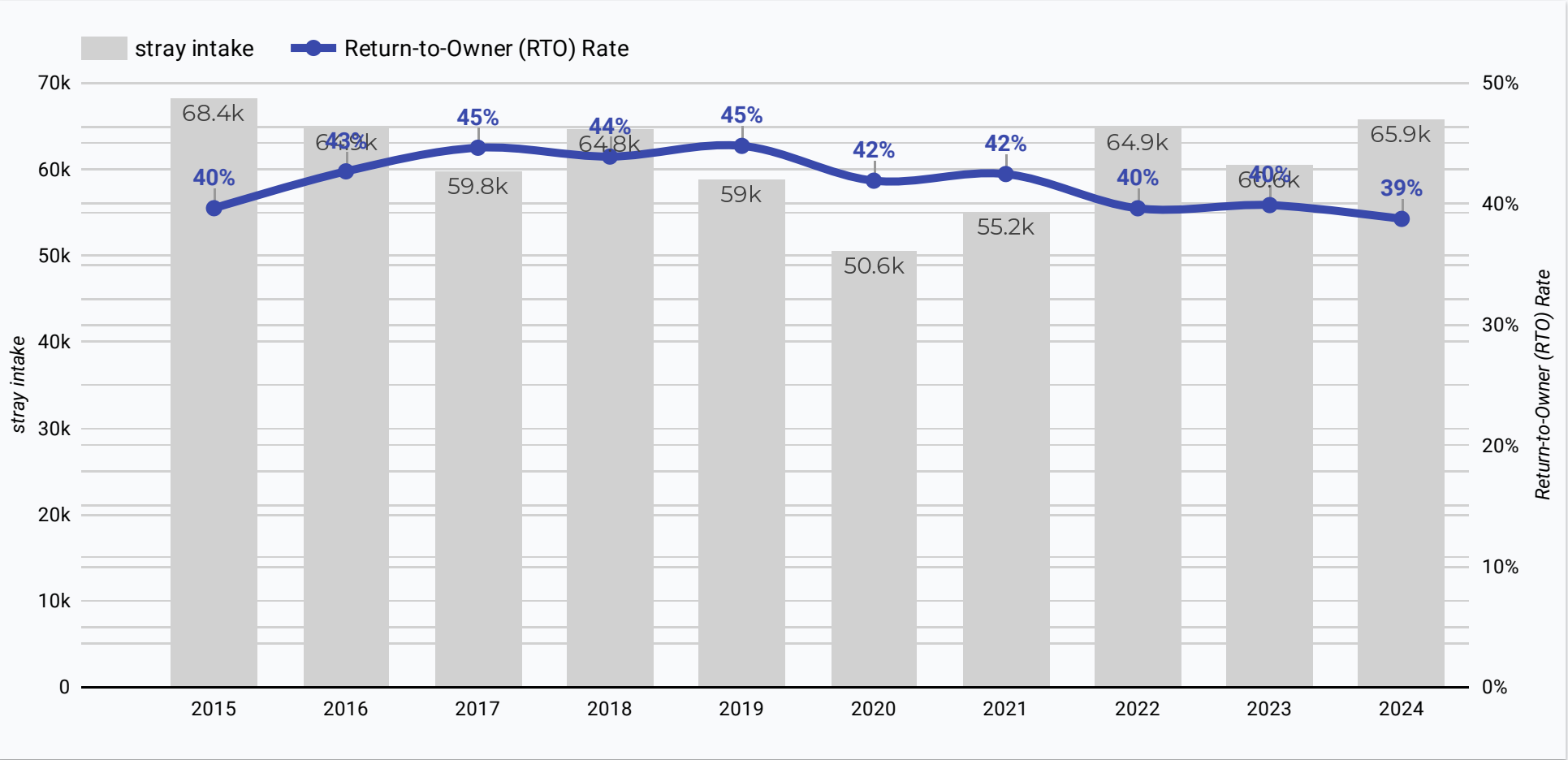
**What “Return-to-Owner” (RTO) means:** RTO refers to animals — usually strays — who are reclaimed by their families after entering the shelter. It’s one of the most important lifesaving programs in the No Kill Equation, under Proactive Redemptions. So RTO rate is 33% means that 33% of the stray animals who entered were reunited with their families rather than being adopted or transferred.

**How RTO rate is calculated**  
It’s calculated as RTO outcomes ÷ stray intakes (that year). Intake timing affects which year the animal is included in, but not the integrity of the RTO rate itself — as long as the shelter reports consistently and transparently.

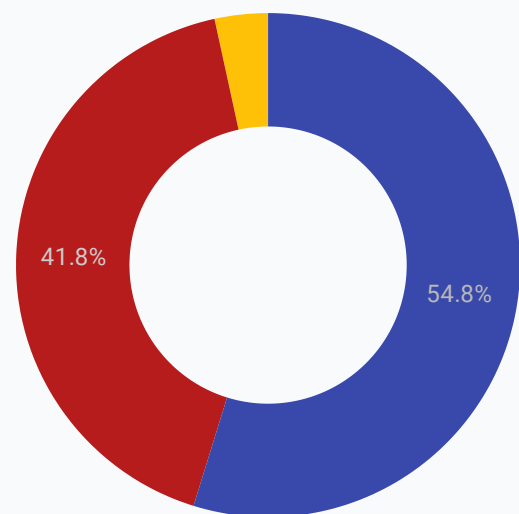
**Year-end intake and outcome** totals rarely match exactly — animals cross over between years. Intake timing affects which year the animal is included in, but not the integrity of the RTO rate itself — as long as the shelter reports consistently and transparently.

**Why accurate RTO data matters**  
The RTO rate is not just a number — it’s a lifesaving indicator. Higher RTO rates mean: Fewer animals enter the adoption or rescue pipeline. Fewer animals are at risk of euthanasia for “space.” The community and shelter are working together proactively — scanning microchips, checking lost pet reports, returning animals in the field, etc. These are all key to No Kill success.

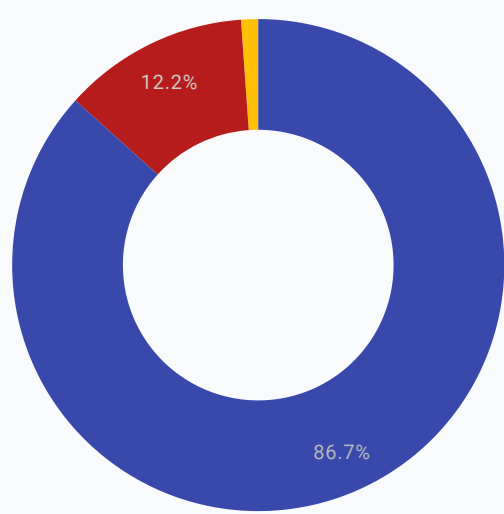
Total Statewide RTO Trend (All Animals)



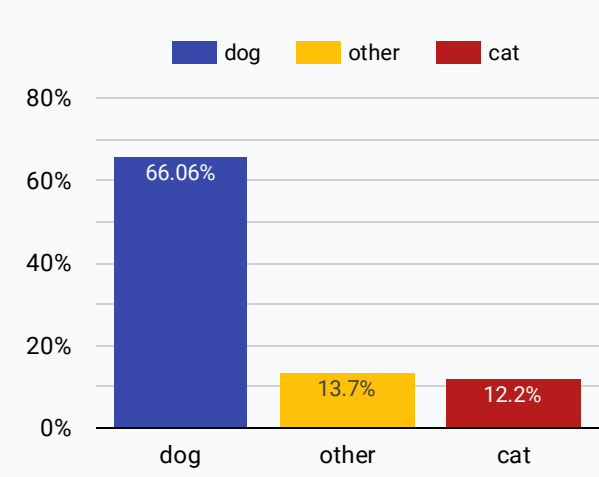
Stray Intake Volume



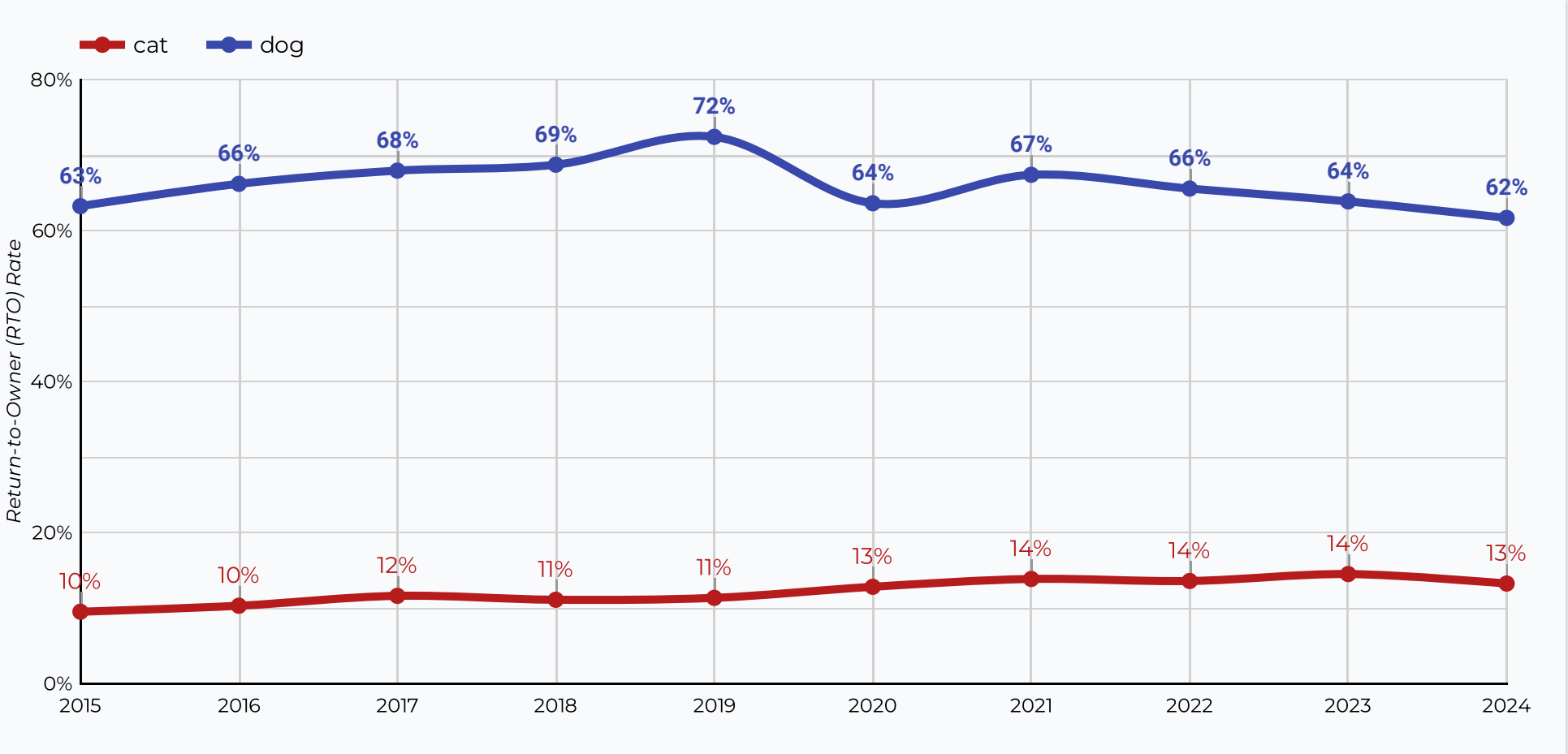
Return to owner Volume



Average RTO Rate



RTO Disparity: Dog vs. Cat Trends

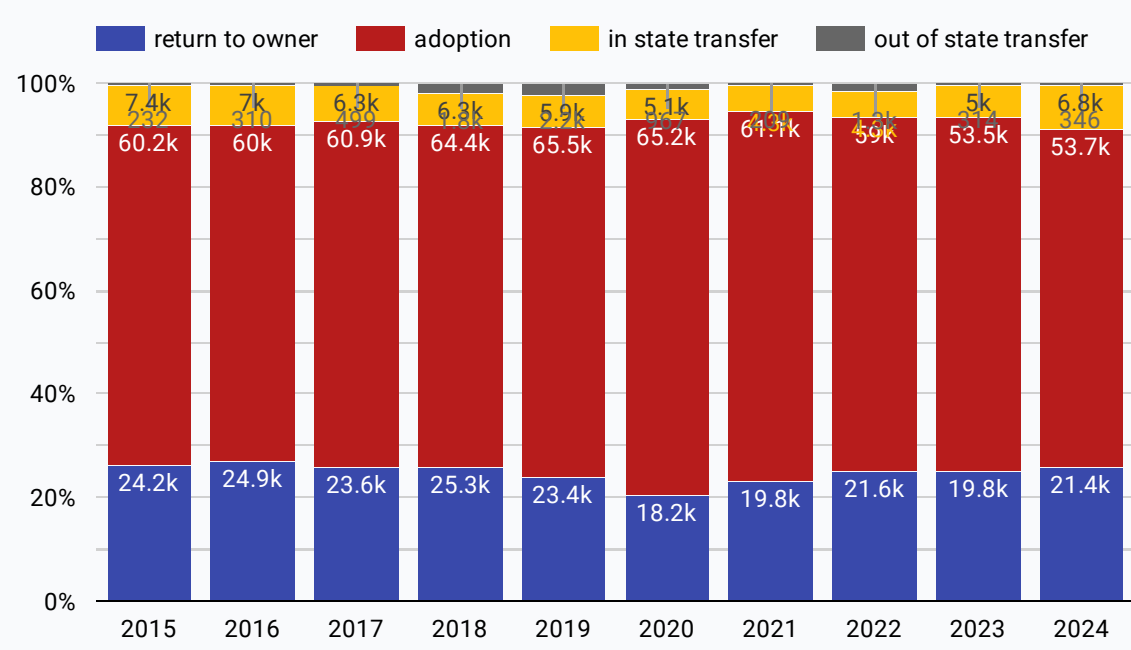


**RTO disparity:** While overall cats presents 42% of the stray animal intake, they represents only 12% of all the animals returned to the owners, which are mostly dogs (87%). Overall RTO Rate for cats is 18%, which is 3 times less than for dogs (56%).

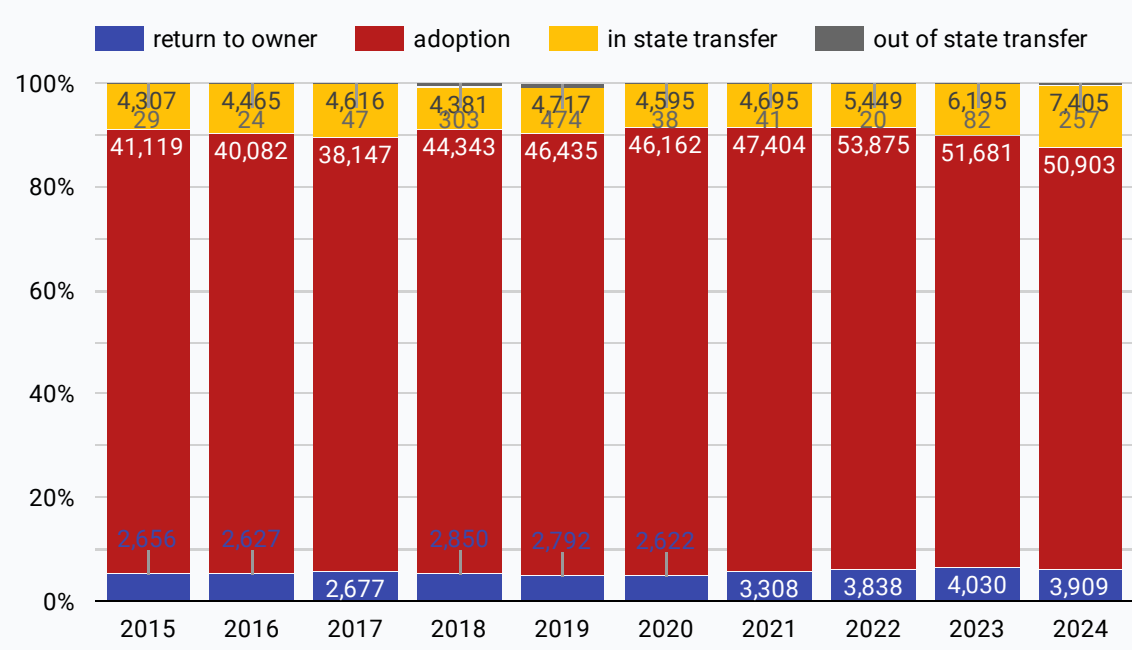
**Critical Core Insight:** The No-Kill effort is heavily driven by strong Dog Reunification rates. However, the system faces a persistent operational challenge with Cat Reunification, where RTO rates remain significantly lower. This disparity confirms the need for two separate strategies.

Positive Outcome Pathways and RTO role

Dog Life-Saving Pathways Over Time



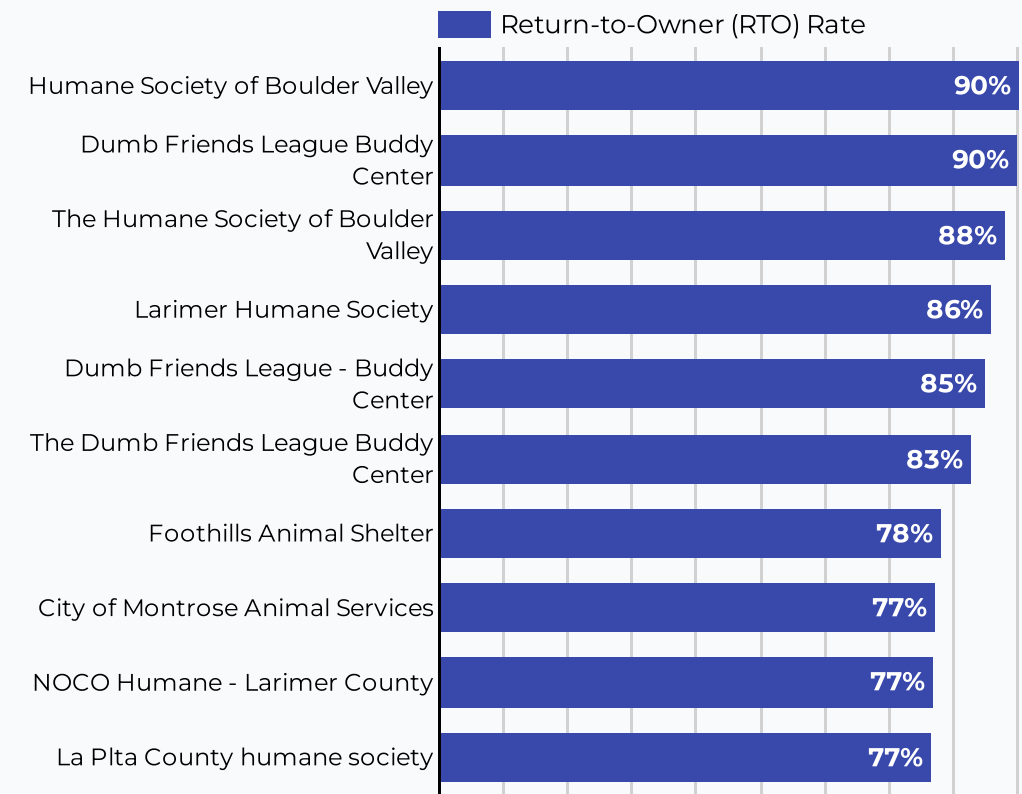
Cat Life-Saving Pathways Over Time



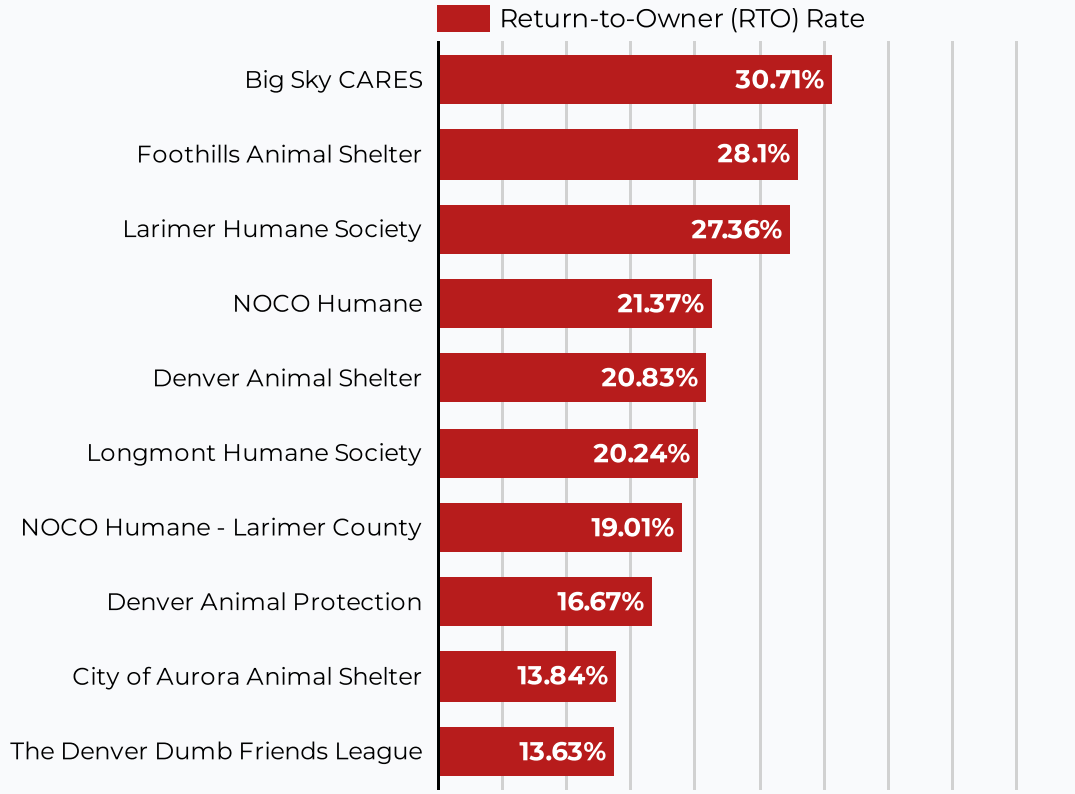
**The full life-saving strategy** is bifurcated by species. For dogs, RTO accounts for the largest share of positive outcomes, confirming the efficiency of current field services. For cats, the system relies on high volumes of Adoption and Transfer programs to move animals out of the shelter. This divergence confirms that to increase overall life-saving efficiency, we must strengthen Cat RTO programs, thereby reducing reliance on the capacity limits of adoption and transfer pipelines.

Return-to-Owner (RTO) Leaders

Dogs: Top 10 Facilities by RTO



Cats: Top 10 Facilities by RTO



**Identifying RTO Leaders:** Facilities with both high RTO rate and volume are critical models for the state. They demonstrate effective, high-volume reunification and should be analyzed for best-practice dissemination across low-performing groups.

Note: In some cases, Return-to-Owner (RTO) rates exceed 100%. This typically occurs when a facility reunifies animals that were not counted as 'Stray Intake' in the same reporting year (due to timing lag). To prevent these outliers from distorting the Top 10 Leaders charts, we have set a minimum requirement of at least 500 stray animal intakes.

STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONS: RTO AS THE KEY TO NO-KILL SUCCESS

1. The Role of RTO and the Core Challenge

The **Return-to-Owner (RTO) Rate** is not just a metric; it is a fundamental life-saving indicator and a key component of the No-Kill Equation. Higher RTO success reduces the number of animals flowing into the adoption/transfer pipeline, which immediately reduces the operational burden on shelters and lowers the risk of euthanasia for space.

The **primary strategic challenge to the No-Kill goal is the persistent Cat Reunification disparity**. Our data confirms that the Cat RTO Rate is significantly lower (average ~12%) than the Dog RTO Rate (average ~66%), indicating the system relies on high-volume adoption and transfer programs to save feline lives. While the Dog RTO rate is strong, 34% of stray dogs still enter the adoption pipeline.

2. Action Plan: Implementing Proactive Redemptions

To drive the entire state closer to maximal life-saving efficiency, we must strengthen RTO for all species by implementing proactive programs based on external evidence:

- Prioritize Proactive Microchipping for All:** External evidence shows microchipped dogs are 2.4 times more likely to be returned and microchipped cats are 21 times more likely to be returned. Investment in low-cost, high-volume microchipping is the most effective single intervention. \*A study of more than 7,700 stray animals (dogs & cats) entering U.S. shelters found: dogs without microchips were returned to their owners 21.9% of the time, whereas microchipped dogs were returned 52.2% of the time. For cats the numbers were ~1.8% (non-chipped) vs ~38.5% (microchipped). nysapf.org
- Mandate Database Standardization and Education:** The efficacy of microchipping is limited by outdated or unregistered data. Targeted community education must be launched to ensure registration upkeep and effective use of lost-and-found platforms, directly improving the operational success of all reunification leaders.
- Replicate Dog Best Practices:** High-performing facilities (e.g., those in the Dog RTO Leaders chart) should be analyzed to scale their successful field services and reunification protocols statewide to achieve a state-wide Dog RTO rate exceeding 60%.

Summary

**Closing the RTO gap for cats while driving dog RTO to its maximum potential is the most cost-effective path to reduce shelter intake burden and secure the No-Kill future.** Every successful RTO frees up resources, making the achievement of the final No-Kill goals both more attainable and more cost-effective.



Data ChangeMakers

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